TEXTILES

BOOSTING FABRIC FORTUNES

A critical engine for economic growth and employment, the sector needs robust government support to navigate global headwinds

By SONAL KHETARPAL

India's textile industry weaves a vital thread into the nation's economic tapestry, contributing 2.3 per cent to the GDP, 13 per cent to industrial production and 12 per cent to exports. The textiles and apparel sector—the country's second-largest employer, directly engaging 45 million workers and indirectly supporting 100 million more in allied industries—is especially significant as India grapples with an unemployment crisis.

With a 4 per cent stake in global trade, exports are projected to surge at a 10 per cent CAGR from 2019-20, reaching $190 billion (Rs 15.9 lakh crore) by 2025-26. That said, the industry's heavy reliance on exports exposes it to challenges. The slowdown in western markets and ongoing conflicts disrupting trade routes have reduced India's export volumes. "The government should prioritise the textile sector not only for its significant annual revenue contribution but also for its critical role in employment-generation," asserts Animesh Saxena, general secretary of the Garment Exporters & Manufacturers Association. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

CENTRAL POLICY
Currently, most schemes for the sector are state-led, resulting in regional disparities in benefits. What's needed is a central textile policy focused on scaling up, subsidies for capital investment and capacity-building

RESKILLING
The Sector Skill Council for textile workers primarily focuses on training the new entrants. With rapid technological advancements, the workforce needs programmes for reskilling

IMPORT DUTIES
Man-made fibres dominate 65 per cent of the global market, but due to uncompetitive duty structures for the import of raw materials, India struggles to compete in this lucrative segment

INCENTIVES FOR SMALL INDUSTRIES
The PLI scheme for textile industry currently targets manufacturers with a turnover of over Rs 100 crore. Small-scale manufacturers also need incentives to grow



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

GIRIRAJ SINGH, 71 | BJP
Minister of Textiles

↘ **The Bhumihar face** A prominent Bhumihar leader of the party in Bihar, Giriraj Singh graduated from Magadh University in 1971

↘ **Outspoken personality** Known for his fiery rhetoric and controversial remarks, he began his political career as an MLC (2002-2014) before being elected to the Lok Sabha from Nawada

↘ **Three in a row** Shifted and won from Begusarai in 2019; has retained the seat. Held various portfolios in the previous Modi cabinets, including rural development, panchayati raj and animal husbandry

Minister of State

PABITRA MARGHERITA, 49 | BJP

A Rajya Sabha member from Assam, he's also MoS, external affairs